
Marcus Rashford is being 'bullied'? Actually, Scholes 'disgrace' verdict was fair comment...

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Marcus Rashford is being 'bullied'? Actually, Scholes 'disgrace' verdict was fair comment...

Paul Scholes won't claim to speak for anyone. In the past, he barely spoke for himself and some, including [Matt Stead](#), might recall the former midfielder's mute period with some fondness. But while [Scholes' latest outburst has not been well received in some quarters](#), he succinctly summed up the feelings of many Manchester United fans towards another of their former heroes.

[Scholes labelled Marcus Rashford a 'disgrace'](#) for his conduct, demeanour and perceived levels of effort towards the end of his Old Trafford career. Strong words from Scholes at a time he just so happens to be launching a new podcast.

Maybe it is a cynical soundbite carefully crafted by Scholes to amplify the platform more than the message. However thick he might be laying it on, there will be plenty who watched Rashford 'walking...not trying' that broadly agree with his sentiment.

Rashford really ought to have been carried out of Old Trafford shoulder high, if he had to leave at all. The academy graduate was a hometown hero turned national treasure for feeding hungry kids and bothering Tories. For the relationship between Rashford and his boyhood club to turn so sour, there are many with questions to answer.

Steady rightly points the finger at United, a 'broken club' with a 'corroded culture'. He's right. Rashford's United is a sh*tshow compared to Scholes's.

READ MORE: [Why Man Utd traitor Paul Scholes went too far with his attack on Marcus Rashford](#)

But at some point, individuals have to be held accountable rather than just attributing failure to some mysterious, ruinous post-Fergie curse. Rightly, flak is flung at the boardroom and axes swung at managers. The players? They cop it too, mostly for the crime of not being fit to lace the boots of Scholes, Butt, Keane, Beckham, Neville. Many of today's squad, promoted above their levels and high above their ceiling, are being damned by comparison.

But what about the ones who do have the talent to follow in those illustrious footsteps? And those who were reared to view The United Way as a concept vastly different to what it currently represents?

Rashford is one of a few who ticked both boxes. It would have pained him to see what the club was becoming but, unlike the fans, he was in a position to lead a change. The extra adoration reserved for academy graduates also comes with the responsibility of maintaining the standards set by those that came before.

Instead, as Scholes put it, [Rashford 'quit on United'](#). Whether he was exasperated or not, the evidence offers no other conclusion.

Over 18 months, Rashford's actions and demeanour spoke of a player who steadily gave up on his club. Repeated disciplinary breaches, the barely-arsed body language... the writing was on the wall long before Henry Winter posted it on X.

When Ruben Amorim arrived last November, Rashford was certainly not alone in giving the

impression that just going through the motions was too much to ask.

The rotten standards prompted anger from supporters towards many players, most notably Jadon Sancho and Alejandro Garnacho. But those faces are quickly forgotten. The disappointment and regret over Rashford inevitably lingers.

No doubt he was held to a higher standard. Hardly unfair when you consider Rashford's pedigree and his status as one of the club's highest earners. But in the end, the bare minimum was too much bother, an attitude that prompted some sympathy, some acrimony, but now mostly apathy towards the one-time local hero.

"I really struggle to feel happy for him," said Scholes, a stance that [angered Steady](#) and a few more besides. Including [The i's Pete Hall](#), who writes that Scholes' criticism and previous narratives around Rashford amount to 'bullying'. Knowing Pete, once of these parts, that's a genuine belief. And given his leaning towards United, it highlights that no view on Rashford is unanimous.

The witch-hunt in the right-wing media which attempted to smear Rashford amid the activism that prompted so much pride among United fans – that was bullying. Calling out his woefully-slipping standards as a footballer, one awarded one of the highest contracts in the history of his club, is not.

So there are plenty of Stretford Enders who would echo Scholes's sentiment. And that's a reasonable reaction – human, even – in the circumstances. Only the most bitter would take satisfaction should Rashford flop at Barcelona, but neither should United fans be made to feel as though they ought to be cheering him on at the Nou Camp after he chose the path of disinterest out of Old Trafford.

Rashford's thunderb*stard at Newcastle in the Champions League last week will have caused many eyes in Manchester to roll. For United fans know better than anyone how Rashford is capable of such moments of brilliance having witnessed plenty for themselves. But those eyes will have rolled all the way back when news emerged of what followed next.

With a brace at St James' Park to build upon following an otherwise inauspicious start at Barca, Rashford turned up late for duty the following matchday. By two minutes, apparently.

The level of his tardiness does not matter, especially when it is part of a pattern of behaviour. When you have unquestionably fallen upwards to a club as prestigious as Barca, where judgements are still being drawn by a new, hard-to-please manager, team-mates and fans, it is damning that it did not occur to him to be in at 9am, rather than skirting close enough to the 9.30am deadline to miss it.

Damning but no longer surprising. Which goes a long way to explaining why Scholes and many others are returning the indifference that dripped off Rashford as he sloped towards the United exit.

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